

THE RISE OF THE ROMAN EMPIRE

FROM CITY, TO REPUBLIC, TO DOMINANT EUROPEAN EMPIRE

Soon after its foundation in 753 BCE, the city of Rome began fighting its neighbors to gain new territory. Gradually, the Romans became entangled in campaigns in the Italian Peninsula and beyond. By the 1st century CE, the Roman Empire had become the largest Europe had ever seen.

The early growth of Roman territories was slow, with wars against neighbors often threatening the survival of Rome itself. By 290 BCE the Romans dominated central Italy and began expanding into the Italian Peninsula. Rivalry with Carthage led to the three Punic Wars between 264 and 146 BCE, but victories brought the acquisition of territory in Sicily, Sardinia, Spain, and then North Africa itself.

In the early 2nd century BCE the Romans fought campaigns in the Balkans, leading to the annexation of most of Greece in 146 BCE. The pace of acquisition quickened in the later years of the Republic, as generals competed for political power and used

their military successes to bolster their position in Rome. It was in this period that Pompey annexed Syria and Julius Caesar conquered much of Gaul, between 58 and 51 BCE.

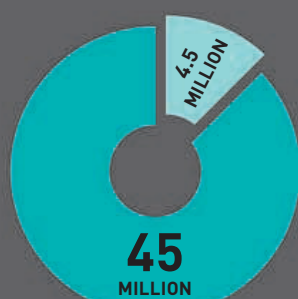
The collapse of the Roman Republic and the accession of the first emperor, Augustus, in 27 BCE did not end the empire's expansion. The quest for security along the existing frontiers resulted in the frontiers being pushed even farther forward. Rome's final large-scale acquisitions were made in the reigns of Claudius, who oversaw the invasion of Britain in 43 CE, and Trajan, who conquered new provinces in Dacia (modern Romania) and Mesopotamia between 106 and 117 CE.

“ TO THE ROMANS I SET NO BOUNDARIES IN TIME OR SPACE. ”

Virgil, Roman poet (70–19 BCE), the god Jupiter, prophesying the future greatness of Rome, from the *Aeneid*



7:1 Roman population
Around 1 CE, the Roman Empire contained about one-seventh of the world's population—45 million out of 300 million people.



An empire of noncitizens
In 1 CE, only a tenth of the Roman population were full citizens. The rest were slaves or had limited civic rights.



Expanding empire
Between the accession of Augustus and the death of Trajan, the Roman Empire almost doubled in size, acquiring vast new territories in northwestern Europe and western Asia.

KEY
Roman territory

100 CE

By around 100 CE, the Mediterranean had become a Roman “lake,” and the acquisition of territories in northwest and Central Europe had brought the northern Roman frontier as far as the Rhine and the Danube.

A GROWING EMPIRE

It took the Romans nearly 500 years to complete the conquest of Italy, but only half that time to enlarge their territories to include Spain, Gaul, parts of Germany, most of the Balkans, much of North Africa, and large parts of western Asia. Over the following 100 years they acquired Morocco, Britain, and Dacia, and made small advances into western Asia, but the empire began to contract after 250 CE.



240 BCE The Romans dominated most of the Italian Peninsula. Victory in the First Punic War (264–241 BCE) brought new territory in Sicily, but the Romans still faced resistance to their rule in northern Italy.

ATLANTIC OCEAN

